Two Ways to Lose a Fantasy Football League

An empirical decomposition of Fat Man's Fantasy, 2016–2025

September 2026

Abstract

Across 56 manager-seasons we decompose league performance into the three components a manager actually controls: the draft, in-season roster acquisition, and weekly lineup selection. Two managers finish near the bottom of the league by mutually exclusive routes. `Gordonulus` is an above-average in-season manager who destroys his rosters in the first four rounds. `mikeion` drafts adequately and then stops playing. We also find no evidence that drafting ability persists across eras ($r = -0.157$), which limits how much of this should be read as skill rather than circumstance.

1 Framework

A season's starting-lineup points can be written as

$$\text{Points} \;=\; \underbrace{f(\text{draft})}_{\text{August}} + \underbrace{g(\text{acquisitions})}_{\text{September–December}} - \underbrace{h(\text{lineup error})}_{\text{every Sunday}} + \varepsilon.$$

Each term is measured on a common scale. A player's contribution is his half-PPR points in weeks 1–14 (playoff weeks are excluded: they decide nothing for a team already eliminated), converted to points above replacement at his own position, with replacement recomputed each season for a 14-team lineup carrying two flex spots. A draft pick is then scored against what a pick at that slot typically returns, so that picking first is not mistaken for drafting well.

Regressing season wins on the three components gives

Component	Wins per SD	Raw r	Partial r
Draft value	+1.19	+0.52	—
Lineup efficiency	+0.54	+0.33	+0.34
Waiver production	+0.33	+0.01	+0.25

Table 1: $n = 56$ manager-seasons, $R^2 = 0.378$.

Waiver production correlates with wins at essentially zero until the draft is held constant, at which point it recovers to +0.25. The two effects had been cancelling: a failed draft *forces* a manager onto the wire, so raw waiver points measure draft failure as much as waiver skill. Note also that $R^2 = 0.378$. Roughly 62% of a season is schedule, injury, and luck.

2 The two failure modes

Six controllable quantities, z-scored across the fourteen managers with at least two full seasons. Higher is better throughout.

Dimension	z-score		raw value	
	`mikeion`	`Gordonulus`	`mikeion`	`Gordonulus`
Waiver volume (claims/season)	−1.74	+0.19	10.3	32.5
Bid discipline ($ over 2nd bid)	−0.90	−0.86	$7.44	$7.33
Waiver efficiency (points/$)	−1.83	−0.65	4.1	6.4
Lineup setting (% of optimal)	−0.74	−0.96	91.8%	91.6%
Early-round value (per pick)	−1.23	−1.48	−26.1	−31.4
Bust avoidance (% of R1–4)	−1.45	−2.03	31%	38%

Table 2: League means: 30.3 claims, $5.21 overpay, 7.6 points/$, 92.5% optimal, −0.6 per early pick, 16% bust rate.

`Gordonulus`: a draft problem

His waiver volume is the only positive number either manager records. He is an active, engaged in-season manager — 32.5 claims a season against a league mean of 30.3, and he twice acquired Matthew Stafford for $3, returning 302 points for six dollars across two seasons.

He loses in August. His bust rate in rounds 1–4 is 38% against a league rate of 16%, the worst mark on any dimension recorded by either manager. His early-round picks average −31.4 points of value each; over four picks that is roughly 125 points a season surrendered before Week 1. His rounds 8–14 are also below water at −11.5 per pick, so there is no late-round recovery.

The pattern is not obviously about age or position — his round 1–4 skill picks average 25.0 years old, *younger* than the league's 26.3. Nick Chubb at pick 6 in 2023 (−157.3) and Elijah Mitchell at pick 47 in 2022 (−93.8) were both bets on running backs returning from injury.

`mikeion`: a participation problem

His draft is mediocre rather than catastrophic, and it is specifically front-loaded: −26.1 per pick in rounds 1–4 but +9.1 per pick from round 8 onward, one of the better late-round records in the league. He is not bad at evaluating players; he is bad at the four picks that matter most.

What separates him from everyone else is the season that follows. At 10.3 claims per season he is last in the league by a factor of three, and he converts 4.1 points per FAAB dollar against a league mean of 7.6. In absolute terms he extracts 252 points a season from the waiver wire; the league median is 692 and the leader is 1,098. Over a fourteen-week season that gap is roughly 60 points a week of unclaimed production.

His claim *win rate* of 63% is the second highest in the league, which is diagnostic rather than flattering. Across the fourteen managers,

$$r(\text{claims per season, waiver points}) = +0.888, \qquad r(\text{price paid per win, waiver points}) = -0.799,$$

$$r(\text{claim win rate, waiver points}) = -0.369.$$

A high win rate means bidding only when certain, and certainty is expensive: he pays $9.40 per successful claim against a league mean of $5.50. Volume, not accuracy, is what the wire rewards.

3 What this is not

Three caveats materially limit the above.

Drafting ability does not persist. Extending the analysis to the MyFantasyLeague seasons of 2016–17, the correlation between a manager's draft performance then and now is $r = -0.157$, 95% CI $[-0.67, +0.46]$. Eight of twelve managers changed sign. The manager with the best four-year draft record in the current era had the worst in the previous one. Pooling all six gradeable seasons, the share of variance attributable to the manager falls from 0.215 to 0.027.

The early-round samples are small. Each manager has 16 picks in rounds 1–4 across four seasons. A 38% bust rate is six events. The waiver figures rest on 1,089 auctions and are considerably more solid.

The dimensions are not equally weighted. A z-score conceals effect size. The entire league sits between 91.1% and 94.1% lineup efficiency; one standard deviation is about 2.8 points per week. The waiver and early-round columns carry real magnitude, the lineup column does not.

4 Conclusion

Both managers finish near the bottom, and the remedies do not overlap. One should draft more conservatively in the first four rounds and would otherwise be fine. The other should open the application on Tuesdays. Neither is doing the thing the other needs to fix, which is why the shared complaint — that they are simply unlucky — is only 62% correct.